4

Some pilots bragged about their engine room. Swaggering, they'd convince you to come for a walkthrough and then beam with pride to point out all the customized details, big and small, that made their ship unique. A captain fixated on speed would talk at length about her hyperdrive systems, while a more cautious pilot might emphasize shields or defense installations. The most brazen would flaunt all the weapons systems and, on rare occasion, a cloaking device. All of them would want to 'take you up for a spin' to show off what the ship could do in realtime, or maybe even challenge you to a competition in the various practice runs that existed in the deep reaches of space.

The bragging didn't come from nowhere. A captain's ship was his pride, the thing into which he sank all of his time and money. His lifestyle did not allow for the trappings of other vocations; a captain owned what fit on his ship, and likely nothing else, since every other aspect of his life–location, friends, family–was inherently transient. The pilot's life was *lonely* and frustrating–there was always more to be done, more that required maintaining–so the ship became both the cause of all his woes and the only means by which he could prove his worth.

In this moment, therefore, Han was questioning his worth, or at least his sanity. The *Starmite*'s guts sprawled out before him, the entire room humming and clicking with a breathing-like rhythm. Every last one of his lamps and the auxiliary lights were on, creating a hot, uncomfortable brightness, and between the heat and his frustration, he'd thrown his shirt off him hours ago. Sweat dripped down his ribcage and an itchy wetness had settled in his groin and between his toes.

Fishing an already damp rag from his back pocket, he wiped at his face for the upteenth time this evening, letting go of an aggravated huff as he did so. The Academy hadn't trained him for this shit, he bemoaned. He'd only been taught how to identify issues and

document them so they'd get forwarded to engineering for actual inspection, diagnosis, and repair. He knew how to fix a swoop bike. He could take the whole damn thing apart and put it back together in between races. But a space-faring vessel? A year in, and he was still out of his element.

He sighed again, clearing the sweat off his forehead in an effort to focus. He didn't get it–they'd picked through this entire engine, each of them taking turns in the tiny room poking and prodding and checking connections, and nothing had jumped out to either of them. Every diagnostic test had continued to report that everything was correct, though obviously it wasn't. They were missing something, but he had no idea what.

What if this isn't a quick fix? he fretted, then banished the paranoia. It wasn't *allowed* to not be a quick fix–he couldn't get stranded in the Core of all places with a busted ship, as much for the inconvenience of it as what it would do to his reputation.

[*It has to be something in between the engine and the navicomputer*] Chewie explained at Han's shoulder. [*Somebody's not talking right to somebody else, and we'll need to reestablish a connection.*]

Han processed the idea slowly. Exhaustion had made his limbs heavy and his thoughts muddy. The prospect of having to pick through the whole ship overwhelmed him. "You got any idea where to start?" he probed. The words came out slow and near slurred.

[*Yes, but we could take a break for a little bit. You look…*] The Wookiee rumbled at him sympathetically.

Han ran a hand through dampened hair then waved Chewie off. "I'm fine. Let's just…let's just take care of this."

Chewie hesitated for a moment, weighing his response, but ultimately pivoted and gestured at the wall of blinking lights behind him–the control panel for the ship's main computer. [*Everything is relayed through here. We might not find the exact spot of the problem, but we'll eliminate a lot of possibilities.*]

Han's mouth skewed. This was going to be tedious, and that was his least favorite type of devoir. Still, it wasn't like he had any choice in the matter. The sooner they started, the sooner it would be over.

They tinkered for the rest of the evening, Han struggling to keep his patience while Chewie happily fussed. The Wookiee liked this kind of thing, and he was good at it. He had a knack for being able to look at a problem multiple ways and systematically test possibilities by the most efficient means, saving time and material and brain power. Without making it too obvious, Han let him take control of this project, the Corellian relegating himself to helper, taking instruction as given. Though loath to admit it, while squirming his way into the back access panel of the ship's controls to disentangle yet another bit of conduit, Han admitted he'd be stuck, *really* stuck, if it weren't for the big lug.

Adjusting his head lamp so he could squint again at the bundle of wires in his hand, Han's fingers felt along the coils until he found the distinctive connection pieces. His thumbs pinched to release the snaps, and the wires came apart into their female and male ends. At his waist was belted an additional cord that connected back to a diagnostic machine he kept on hand for those times he didn't quite trust the ship's petulant computer. He snapped the conduit piece into the diagnostic cord and then could faintly hear the chime from the little machine as it began to process the sudden input of information.

He waited for a few seconds, then became acutely aware of how cramped and hot he felt in what was barely more space than an exhaust vent. He grunted and readjusted a little but in vain. "Anything?!" he yelled, staring down his legs at the square of light beyond his ankles.

Silence met him, and Han started panting. He didn't normally struggle with claustrophobia–being stuck in tight spaces sometimes was part of the job–but the heat choked him. Thirst had thinned his

vision. Whatever the answer was from Chewie, the day was *over*, and he needed out of this damn compartment.

The huge roundness of Chewie's head popped into the opening. [*We found it*] he announced brightly, barking a laugh, then swatted at Han's legs. [*Hook it back up and get out of there*.]

Relief washed over him, and Han found a small burst of vigor to put all the pieces back together as they belonged. He crawled out carefully from the belly of the ship, noticing only as he stood how greatly his back and arms ached from awkwardly propping himself up. Frowning, he rubbed at his forearms. "And? What is it?"

Chewie gestured to a three dimensional schematic of the ship on the main computer screen. [*It's not the valves. We thought it was, but that's not why we couldn't kick in to hyperspace. The hyperdrive is charging up just fine, but the hyperdrive motivator isn't talking correctly to the computer. I'll want to look at it again, now that I think I know what I'm looking for, but I suspect there's something frayed on the motivator*.]

"We checked the motivator already," Han started aggravatedly.

[*Yeah, we did, but I said I think it's faulty, not broken. It works sometimes, and then it doesn't*.]

His breath came out in a heavy, long exhale through his nose as he processed. "So, what then?"

[*If I'm right, then what we should probably do is black box it. Something on there is fried, or half-fried, and we'll kill ourselves trying to repair every little connection*.]

Han nodded, reflecting. A circuit board, of all the possibilities it could have been, was a relatively easy fix from a mechanical and an electrical perspective. To find one compatible with a Sorosuub *Starmite* hyperdrive motivator, however, would likely prove significantly more difficult. Sorosuub ceased making parts for this model ship almost before he was born, and Shug had not been exaggerating when he said Sorosuubs did not take well to off-brand fixes. If that was all he could find, he'd install it, but he accepted he

risked putting himself in the same conundrum at some point down the line.

Resolved, his lower lip jutted out. "Okay, fine," he finally answered, weary. "But in the morning."

Chewie didn't argue and instead turned to put up the diagnostic machine. Han strolled away, still overwhelmed, but as the lamps clicked off behind him, the influx of darkness offered solace from at least one of his triggers. He crossed to the galley and tiredly retrieved a mug, then pushed it under the water spout.

Only after his third refill did the haze in his head clear. A quick rinse would be good, and then food. He had gone out the day prior to get something quick for dinner and fetch a sizable delivery of stimm tea to take back with him, but in doing so, had passed a market and couldn't help himself. After all, Esseles would have all kinds of produce and dairy and meat and more that he'd never find on Nar Shaddaa, simply for lack of demand. Perusing the butchery, he'd come across a fantastic stock of eopie thigh. He'd balked at the price–everything in this damn sector was extortionary–but some finessing with the clerk scored him a deal: he could take the leftover scraps from a big order that was in the process of being filled at a steep discount. As he pulled his prize from the cooler, he mused, *One man's trash…*

Chewie continued to fiddle around with the ship's computer while Han began dinner. *Gornarr*–a Wookiee recipe of cheap and easy dough, all stuffed and spiced, then baked–never failed to please, especially when he had such good protein. He gave the meat a thorough mincing, then set it aside while he diced and sauteed some vegetables.

As his aromatics hit the pan, the swirl of steam and smell bloomed in his face, invoking memory. Nothing specific jumped back to him–he'd done this exact motion so many times with these exact ingredients–but rather it was a hodgepodge of jumbled visuals and sounds…and a feeling, too, one of warmth. Nostalgia. He never forgot, exactly, but this…this was hard to access most of the time. He grinned as the feeling seeped in deeper, enveloping him, enjoying the

sensation of uncoiling as his stress evaporated. Pushing the medley around to brown properly, he could almost hear Dewlanna behind him, scolding him for touching the ingredients too frequently, for not letting the *pan* do the work to make the food deepen in flavor. He was perpetually impatient, she'd critiqued, and he'd have to rein himself in if ever he wanted to turn victuals into meals.

As it always did, though, the feeling could not linger. The suspension of reality could only last for so long, and as soon as he became conscious of his yearning–to not have to let go of the sensation too quickly, to let him stay steeped in a memory, a certain *kind* of memory–the warmth imploded. In its wake came an abrupt, graying wash of pain. Shame. It twisted his diaphragm, made taut his brow and squared his jaw, and he clenched his back teeth against the return of the perpetual knot in his chest. He grimaced as he scraped the pan's contents into a bowl, eager to preoccupy himself with nothing else but the task at hand.

By the time the pastry came out of the oven, all puffed and steamy, Han was almost beside himself with hunger. Chewie, too, though little else could be expected of him. He came into the small lounge, huffing in air through an open mouth to pre-taste his food. He came in closer, crowding Han to gape over the human's shoulder, then cocked his head.

[*Is this gornarr*?] he questioned, sucking in two more inhales as though to confirm.

"Why, what's the matter?" Han returned, defensive.

[*Nothing wrong*] the Wook snipped back slightly. [*Just didn't know you knew about this*.]

Han eyeballed his copilot quickly, then resumed plating himself two of the savory pastries. "I knew about factryn meat pies."

[*Everybody knows about factryn meat pies*] Chewie countered, stepping up to the platter once Han left to inspect the *gornarr* closer. His nail punctured the center of one, allowing for a puff of steam, and his attention ran around the crimped edge. [*These*

look authentic] the Wookiee continued, his surprise apparent. [*Who taught you how to make these*?]

Han, already mid-slice to divide the pastry into cooler, more manageable bites, couldn't help but flinch at the question. His hand hovered for a beat, again bracing against the sting of shame, before he tossed his head to the side. "Don't need a tutor to roll dough," he answered offhandedly. "Used to read cookbooks. In my downtime."

The Wookiee chuffed, clearly finding some part–but maybe not sure which–he found unbelievable. He plated some for himself, then in the limited space of the lounge, crowded next to Han at the small table. For a while, they ate in silence.

[*It's good*] Chewie eventually offered as he finished his first. [*Needs more heat.*] The big furry hand reached into the nearby utility cup and pulled out an almost empty bottle of X'errian hot sauce. The Wooks all liked spice. Chewie preferred straight lava.

Again, Han eyed him, unsure how much the compliment was genuine and how much it was planted to soothe. The Wook did that sometimes–caught the tension between them and said something nice just to try to get him to forget. But Chewie's attention shifted to consuming a second, and only then, with the eyes off him, did Han manage a 'thank you' through a mouth stuffed with food.

It was quiet for a few more beats until Chewie broke the peace. [*Any more word on the girl*?]

Han couldn't stop the bitter smirk that slid up his face. Buttering him up–that's what the compliment had been for. The Wook was getting better at it. In response, part of Han wanted to snap back, to tell the nosey giant to mind his business, that Han had it handled, that things were fine, but he swallowed his bite first, jaw tightening. "She's been good about being in contact. And I've checked her location–she's been back and forth to the theater like she said." He omitted all the trailing he'd done around her the last two days, ostensibly trying to retrace the steps of someone he'd invented from "before."

[*And the Palace has said nothing else*?] Chewie's words came

out leading with a distinct, skeptical edge.

Han busied himself at pulling apart his next pastry, doing his utmost to stay nonchalant. If he fidgeted too much, Chewie would press harder and perhaps pull out from him that he'd been kind of vague in his transmission to Nar Shaddaa. If he vacillated too much or didn't answer, it would also rouse suspicions. "Just said they were glad we made it okay," he finally answered casually.

To his relief, the Wookiee accepted the answer and went quiet, focused again on his meal. He bit and chewed at a third *gornarr*, his blue eyes staring off. [*She seems like she's kind.*]

When Chewie paused at the audible scoff Han gave in response, the latter frowned. "She *seems* nice. Real good at getting you to believe it. I don't buy it–those artsy types all got an addiction to self-importance." He shook his head as his fingers scraped across the plate, picking up the filling that had escaped him and cramming it in. "Just dressed up salespeople," he alleged, struggling over the mouthful.

Chewbacca snorted. [*Well, you wouldn't recognize 'kind' if it hit you over the head.*]

For a moment, Han bristled, then swiftly decided he'd ignore the comment, then just as swiftly decided that if he gave Chewie dead air, the Wook would find some other pesky way to fill it. Emphatically, as though the question had just come to him, he asked, "Hey, did you verify your little theory? It's something with the circuit board?"

A different part of Chewie's brain, the engineer, took over. [*I'm positive. I wrote out a serial number for you to locate the right part.*]

"Sorosuub part number?" Han queried.

Chewie tilted his head to affirm. [*I can try and find some alternatives before you leave in the morning, but–*"

"We both know how that will go," Han interrupted. He griped–as he'd done more than once since arriving–that this issue had cropped up *now* and of all places *here*. Why not as they'd been coming into Nar Shaddaa?! Shug would have been able to source him

a decent part at a fair price, and even helped him install it at the cost of a beer or three. Or, he gulped to remember, that nasty oil sludge the mechanic claimed was liquor.

The expense was the least of his problem, though. To come to this place already meant a risk, but to have to walk around it, to interact with people, to be seen…that meant something more. Esseles had enough layers and sectors that the likelihood of running into anyone he recognized–or who recognized him–was small, but not zero. He'd need to be prudent about where he stepped.

He wiped his hand across his mouth, as much to clear the crumbs as to soothe. "I won't have much luck finding anything around here. It's too frilly, and even if I do find it, it'll be too expensive. I'll have to head out. Probably kinda far."

* * *

Morning came quicker than he wished. He went through the routine of his morning wash and half-heartedly ate a semblance of breakfast. At least he enjoyed a well-made cup of stimm, he reasoned. Fueled for what would likely be a very long day, he entered his bunkroom to change. He picked through his small satchel to find a dark green tunic, another pair of black slacks, and a set of undergarments. Once clothed, he sat at the edge of his bunk to put on his boots.

He looked them over–broken in, desperately in need of a polish. They were one of the few things he'd kept, or rather, had been *allowed* to keep, since they were customized to his feet. They were extremely comfortable, but also unmistakably regulation, their design standardized to his former rank. He clenched his jaw to think that they might cause someone to start asking questions. *Secondhand shop*, he decided as he shoved a foot inside. *That's what I'll say if anyone asks*.

Silver Quarry lay inland, much more so than the seaside of Calamar, hidden away so as not to mar or contaminate the polish of

the capital. At the transit station in the center of the Arts District, he could pick up a maglev that would have him pounding heels through shipyards and mechanics' shops in all of half an hour. He'd already walked all around the Arts District, and by and large, his pressing angst about being here had mostly ebbed. Certainly, anyone who might recognize him wouldn't be here. It was going farther out, going into the grit, where he risked being identified. Even a hail from an old youth tournament fan right now would be unwelcome. No attention was ideal. Last thing he needed was someone making a fuss about him, and then it somehow getting found out that whatever name the fan called him by wasn't the name on his ID. What spiral of bullshit that would cause.

The transit station sat roughly a twenty minute walk from his landing pad, depending on how crowded the streets and funiculars were. He might be able to get there faster if he took the gondolas, he considered as he stepped out from the building's lobby, craning his neck to take them in, but he just as quickly decided against it. Something about being up high like that, just strung out on a too-thin thread of cord felt *wrong*. He'd walk, keep his feet on solid ground.

Walking down the avenue, he frowned again at the city. The crispness it had. The edges too fine. Sharp, like he'd cut himself on them. And the businesses that lined the street, least those he could recognize from other worlds, were the companies that had caved to the demands of the Imperial Economic Council: use the Imperial credit *only*; only do business with others who were in the Accord; and end any contracts as necessary to maintain a flimsily-defined "peace." Any economic activity outside of those parameters would swiftly and decisively be deemed an attempt to support dangerous factions, or worse, "anarchist" groups. Even its demographic composition was too uniform. The planet had a sizable portion of Bothans prior to Imperial incorporation; now, every sentient he spotted was human.

His chest heaved. How insulated from all of it he'd been for so long. Even as he'd gotten old enough to see the truth for what it was, he'd been too consumed in his immediate ventures–the next race, the

next improvements to the bike, and watching for Shrike's next move. The conniving fucking assholes. How they twisted and manipulated and misinformed to their benefit. And him…smart as he was–*dammit*, he was smart, he wouldn't have survived Shrike for so long if he wasn't–he had been so damn eager for a new start that he'd put blinders on to everything that should have come up inconvenient. Uncomfortable. Wrong.

He was on a funicular nearing the bottom tier of the city when he came back to his senses. *A long time ago*, he reminded himself, and farther away each day. The events of the last year had fully removed any allegiance to a version of himself that he once thought he could be. *Should* be. The way the Imps had kicked in his face had embedded a deep resentment towards everything and everybody. He had decided then that he would worry about no one but himself, care for no one but himself, align himself to nothing and no one. Well, maybe he'd never really given up those beliefs entirely, but his exit had hardened them into transparasteel. Hutt Space had made for quite a good fit in that way.

Refocusing, he moved with the crowd as they departed the carriage, walking faster than even the people in front of him to hurry into the station. He tapped his transit card and hustled down an additional set of stairs to bring him to the platform for the Silver Quarry maglev, only to read the display board and find it would be another fifteen minute wait. He huffed, irritated.

He drifted to a column, posted up with a line of sight to the stairs and the platform edge, and let his eyes do their usual sweep. Ads pulsed along the far wall in soft pastels—perfume, a home droid, some wellness clinic—then a wider banner animated across the length of the holo. The Togatto Speedway in Nurrale. The footage cut quick: a low-slung racer threading a stone chicane; stands of color-blocked pennants; a finish-line shot on a pale oval with the sea glittering beyond it.

His mouth tugged. Togatto—he recognized that course. He'd run a modified version of it, of course, the track slightly simplified in

comparison to the podracers, but he'd run it nonetheless. To his chagrin, the images stirred memories he'd not accessed in a long time, maybe even since he'd lived them. They'd landed in Alabar in some other random ship they'd hopped from Calamar, Shrike's *Trader's Luck* already too infamous to bring anywhere near the race's headquarters. He'd scoped the track for the Circuit Run, finding the pocket through the course that he figured he could use to shave off time. The way Shrike had been furious at him for coming in second. Struggling to swallow down the slurry of Esselian grain that Dewlanna had made for him while he'd held a frozen bag of pearberries to his forehead to soothe the still-swelling marks of Shrike's knuckles.

Stars above, he grunted, he hated the sonofabitch. Then, plenty. More, now.

His hip buzzed. Relieved for distraction, he pulled his comm link out to read the display screen. As there were only two people on this planet who would reach out to him, and it wasn't Chewie's name that popped up, he put the comm back in his pocket without answering. The girl–Korë, he reminded himself–had called him two days in a row now at 7 in the morning. He hadn't gone around the day before, and he hadn't announced his presence to her since leaving her hotel room a few days ago. It would be smart to remind her he was watching. He could have swung by first thing and been done with it, but securing his equipment mattered more.

Later, he reasoned. Hopefully, this excursion was over quickly, and he could be back before sundown. He hadn't slept enough the night before, nor the night before that, nor the night before that, and having a circuit board in hand would help him relax into a greatly overdue slumber.

The ad rotation clicked to a new spread, saturating the entire station in a wash of red. He squinted into it, then watched a holovid of some winged creature–a skreev, he registered–fly though some cityscape and pluck a laurel and coin up, only to transform into a stylized seal. Big, block letters then materialized, red against a black background: QUITH FINANCIAL.

He blinked, unsure if he'd seen correctly, but the familiar logo still hovered. *I'll be damned*, he breathed. Six months he'd fought with that damn bank about wiring him money. *His* money. No matter how much he'd argued, he kept getting the same insufferable answer: any changes to the account—closure, reassignment, even a balance inquiry beyond a certain limit—required him to appear "in person at any Quith branch for biometric verification." That was never going to happen; he wasn't going to *choose* to head anywhere near Imperial space, even for the sizable amount in the account, so he'd blown it off. Honestly, he'd forgotten about it.

The thought flickered in his brain–*I'm already here*–but he shut it down swiftly. To be here at all was already pushing his luck. To walk around and interface with a bunch of people as he would today would be pushing his luck. To go to Quith Financial, to have to submit himself to a fingerprint and retina scan, to have to present his old ID…the idea twisted his stomach so much, it made him nauseous. That money was a lost quarry, he admitted ruefully. Another casualty to the fucking Empire.

Lost in his rumination, he only noticed the Imperial patrol when the white plastoids figurines stopped moving just at his periphery.

Stiffly, he examined them: three faceless troopers in a neat line, a fourth in uniform a step back, datapad in hand. Everything about their posture suggested casual patrol, but the flickering attention of the rear leader–a lieutenant, Han read quickly–meant interrogation.

"Identification," the leader demanded, his tone a petty authority thinly wrapped in decorum.

"Problem?" Han asked, his alias ID in hand before his pulse caught up. He kept his shoulders level, chin neutral as he handed it over.

"We're searching for someone," the officer reported, staring hard at Han. He then flicked his attention from the holostill of the ID to Han's face and back. "Business on Esseles, Mister…Tenner?"

"*Captain* Tenner. Delivery," Han answered, his voice flat and bored. It needed to sound routine to him as much as them. "Need a part in the Quarry."

The lieutenant placed the ID on his scanner, and while the device processed, he glanced Han up and down. "You've been through Imperial space before." It wasn't a question.

A prickling crawled at his collar. "Here and there."

"More than here and there," the man crooned, eyes on Han's boots. "Service?"

The phrase 'secondhand shop' flitted through his consciousness, though he couldn't remember why now. Something about the condescension of the officer's stiff regard had short-circuited his system. He'd never really adjusted to that.

He held the man's eyes just long enough. "Once."

"Once?" the lieutenant returned, the pitched up way he said it as a suggestion of some irregularity.

A sneer started to form on Han's lip at the officer's snide self-satisfaction, and he pursed his lips harder against it. "Didn't renew my contract."

The man's eyes narrowed, his brow pinching at his temple. His mouth opened to pester further, but in his hesitation to find the right prod, a wall of air and deafening sound announced the arrival of the maglev. Neither man broke eye contact, in the stillness both acknowledging that the moment had passed.

The lieutenant's mouth did something like a smirk and then didn't. Curtly, he handed back the ID. "Enjoy your stay."

"Pleasure," Han offered dryly, not taking his time to tuck the ID away again before he jogged for the maglev. He quickly took a seat in a small alcove in the very last car, then peered out the window to check the platform again. They'd already stopped someone else, and now were moving to rope in a third. How ridiculous the troopers looked as they reanimated, like toys transformed into men again. Allegedly.

Han watched them snatch up identification cards, and the girl's words echoed in his head. Resentfully, he agreed: pigs in polished boots.

Cresting the stairs of the terminus station, Han did a visual sweep of his surroundings. He found himself square in the middle of a hectic metropolis, the graceful tiers of Calamar replaced here with buildings that loomed above him, almost bowing over the street and creating a long shadow that cast the dingy corridors in half-darkness even at the morning hour. Storefronts and advertisements cluttered the visual space in a dizzying array of colors and sharp movement, and the permacrete had given way in spots to the ever-churning hive of denizens.

This main drag would not offer him what he needed, or certainly not at the price point he was comfortable with; even this was too cultivated and the shopsellers too skilled at plucking credits from the fingertips of customers too timid to wander further into the reaches of the sector. Unarmed, he'd need to keep his eyes and ears open, even more so than he already did. He didn't know exactly where he was headed, but he'd know the right place when he saw it: small, quiet, dirty. The best shops were like Shug's, all unassuming and gritty in their appearance, and the best mechanics always looked like they just stepped out from four years in a Devaronian prison.

He walked all day. All day, in and out of shops, waiting to be seen by understaffed front desks, all day explaining to person after person what he wanted, arguing with obstinate mechanics that what he really did need was a new circuit board, only to be told time and again that they didn't even have his part on site. Asking for guidance about where to go next or who might have one likewise proved a fruitless pursuit–business was business, and no shop was willing to push even an empty-handed customer into another's door. Only when a fellow customer who'd been eavesdropping stopped Han with a grasp of his elbow as he stormed his way out of yet another mechanic

shop did the Corellian learn of one last place that was worth checking out. It was a bit of a jog, almost past the border of the sector, but going would put him back in the direction of the Arts District and his bunk, so Han gave stiff thanks to the Soroccan and headed off.

Nightfall had started by the time he arrived, and Han found himself in a cheerless area of the sector. He located his intersection and posted at the corner, eyeballing up and down both streets until he saw it: the flickering blue-purple sign for 'Tomansen's Hull' that offered the only light in the tight alleyway. It was exactly the kind of place where an idiot might meet his end, strolling alone and too brazenly into the unknown. He would watch for a couple minutes, just to get a sense of the place.

It was dinnertime, and the scattered denizens moved languidly either towards or away from their last meal. He'd eaten at lunchtime–some kind of a sausage from a taciturn street vendor–but his stomach growled. More pressing though was the exhaustion that permeated down into all his extremities. His feet ached, and aware again of the swelling and the pain, he shifted his weight around. He was toast–after this, no matter how it panned out, he was done. What pleasure it would be to go back to the ship, to strip his boots off, and stretch out in his bunk. Momentarily, he swooned at the promise, then headed in.

Clutter jumped out at him right away. That, and a familiar metallic smell mixed with the fumes of solder and mechanical grease. *Passed the first check*, Han reckoned as he picked his way toward the front desk. The place would be closing soon, he figured, but he could at least talk to someone and get the ball rolling. The customer service desk was ill-defined and set well back from the front door. In fact, the only reason Han was able to locate it was that a man in a jumpsuit–unquestionably an employee–ducked behind it quickly. Han sped up before the man–a human, pitying ugly–got swept up in another task.

"Hey," Han called out firmly, catching the man's attention, "you got a hyperdrive motivator circuit board for a *Starmite*?"

The man gaped at Han before answering. "A Sorosuub *Starmite*?"

Han stared blankly. *Is there another company that makes* Starmite*, you idiot*. "Yes," he answered flatly. "A Sorosuub. I have a part number."

The man received the piece of flimsy then accessed his computer. Silent, he entered the data and clicked through screens. Critiquing his findings, he drummed his fingers on the keypad. "I don't have anything *Starmite* on the lot. But I do have an old Sorosuub yacht, and she ain't good for nothin' but pieces at this point. Her part doesn't match exactly, but it's a model year newer, and if I remembered right, Sorosuub had given up at that point at innovating. It might take a little finagling, but you should be able to get it to fit."

Han stifled his exhale of relief. It mattered how much he revealed about how bad he needed it. He needed to stay neutral. Skeptical or aloof, even better. He picked his head up to feign thinking, shifting his weight around on his feet. "D'you know what kinda condition it's in?" he asked, wincing with doubt.

"Won't be sure until we dig it out. I'm guessing it's still sharp, though–that yacht's back there with her interior all stripped out, but her guts are still good. Would you need install?"

Han waved him away. "No, I got my own guy." And then, the question he dreaded. "How much you lookin' for it?"

The man fussed about on his inventory computer for a moment. "It will depend on what condition it's in. If it's in excellent shape, which I'll bet it is, then about seven licks."

Han's eyes bulged out of his head. He'd expected this guy to price gouge him, but not so blatantly. "Seven hundred?" Han reiterated, his voice high. He clenched his jaw, trying to regain hold of himself. Cool and rational–that's what would get him the best price. "Is that parts and labor, or–?"

"All in," the clerk answered, then read another screen.

Han remained still for a moment, considering his options. Part of him toyed with the idea of simply leaving the hyperdrive as

faulty and taking their chances getting back to Nar Shaddaa, but a creeping concern warned him not to. And Chewie…he'd never hear the end of it if that's what he returned and told the Wookiee, *especially* if there ended up being repercussions for delaying again the necessary repairs.

"If you want it, so you know, it'll be about a week."

This perked Han's ears. "Oh? You got somebody on vacation?"

"Nah," the guy answered. "Just busy."

Internally, Han lit up: he'd found his advantage. "Well, what if I got back there and picked it out for your guys? Save you the hassle?" *And save me the cost of labor.*

"Employees only in the warehouse." The man read Han's immediate frown. "That's our policy."

Han forced a grin. "I get it," he answered. "If I find someplace else for less, I'm not obligated to buy, am I?"

The clerk snorted a laugh. "I don't think you will, but no, no obligation."

Han noted the confidence with which the man rebuffed him. "Alright," he agreed with a sigh, then scanned his comm to share his contact information. "Maybe I'll see you in a week."

Their goodbyes brief, Han took one last sweeping glance around the shop before he exited to the alley, onto the street, then stopped again at the corner and let everything for the moment just…wait. He let go off a lengthy exhale, the pressure on his chest subsiding a little as he did so. He could go back now, he accepted with satisfaction, *and* had something to show for all his effort. The triumph, however small, brought a mild giddiness to his fatigued limbs. A breeze from somewhere behind him blew past, ruffling the arms of his shirt, and some even slipped down underneath his collar and ran chill down his back. He shivered pleasantly in the gust and turned to let it blow across his face. He'd sleep in the next morning, he decided as he ran a hand across his face and through his hair. Deservedly so.

Aware it was an indulgence, he hailed an airspeeder–a cheap one, to mitigate the guilt. He damn near groaned in pleasure to be off his feet and sank back into the rickety bench. Quickly, his mind turned to recapping his position: he had a lead–and a good one–but wasn't done yet. Seven hundred was much more than he wanted to pay. He did, though, have a week to find another part at a different price–always good to make the suppliers fight over you. The clerk had made clear his opinion on finding such an alternative, but that could simply have been bluffing. He wouldn't know until he dug around a little more, though he'd wrung Silver Quarry dry of what it had to offer. Still, though, barring any success at scrounging up another option, he perhaps had an opportunity to hang the clerk with demand. Who else would want a used part on an outdated ship? Han would be doing him a favor by buying.

His hip buzzed again. He harumphed, predicting a message from Chewie to nag at where he was or what he was bringing back for dinner. He almost audibly swore, however, to read the name that popped up, his head falling into his palm. *The girl*–he'd forgotten about the girl!

For a moment, he questioned whether he couldn't just go in the morning. A tempting proposition–he had little reserves left, and to go to the theater would require he walk *past* the entrance to the tower that housed his landing pad. The thought nearly made him nauseous. He argued with himself that it could wait, that it was no big deal, and that she'd been good about checking in with him. That last part, though…it nagged at him. If *he* were in a position where he wanted away from the Hutts, if *he* was trying to manipulate his way out, that might be exactly the way he did it. Be predictable, test the waters, and then make the escape when no one was the wiser.

He groaned, irritated: he'd go. Hopefully, he could just pop in at the theater, make his appearance for appearance's sake, then hustle back to the 'Suub.

The airspeeder dropped him right at the theater entrance. Han quickly paid and stepped out, stopping and staring at the double

doors. He winced slightly to think back on his last interaction with the girl. She had swing–that was clear–and his mouth had a bad habit of running away from him. She *was* following orders, playing within her boundaries. If she came back all in one piece and felt dissatisfied with his service? Jiliac didn't dislike him per se, but the Hutt always seemed to be teetering on the edge of seeing his usefulness, and any bad mouthing from this girl could seal his fate. She was tight with Deino, too, who wouldn't hesitate to rat him out about skimming. Even Jabba would not be able to intervene on his behalf.

Sucking in a breath to help him find the right disposition, Han pulled on the door to the theater and stepped inside. It was dark in the anteroom, though he could see a slight glow beyond the second set of open doors ahead of him, and he continued forward and peeked inside.

The theater was empty except for her. On stage with only a few overhead lights, she was slowly transitioning from different poses, her arms and feet moving while her head stayed bowed in concentration. It didn't look like dancing, but she was doing something, and artfully.

Han watched, contemplating but confused. Physical objects, like sculptures and paintings, he knew a thing or two about. Those things had tangible value, and knowing what to pick if ever "offered" a selection was a useful bit of information to keep in the back of his head. But the other types of arts, the purely performative ones…suffice to say, he'd never been much of a consumer. There was beauty in it, he could appreciate it that much, and who couldn't enjoy the curves of a svelte woman as she moved around in grand extensions and turns? But distinguishing skill? Difficulty level? Understanding the history of different art movements and music choices and any of the other terms those people threw around? In that, he was lost.

He strolled down the side of the theater. "It's awfully quiet in here," he interrupted.

She gracefully dropped her arms and planted her feet, finishing her move, then raised indifferent eyes to him. "I thought you were going to check on me."

"I'm here, aren't I?" he answered, arms spread. He gestured to the rest of the theater. "Where's everyone else?"

She studied him for a moment, her mouth small. "They've left for the day. It's late."

In her cold tone, he realized he had a lot of ground to cover. "Was that some kind of dance you were doing?" he added hurriedly, hoping to disarm. He wasn't sure if he was faking his interest convincingly enough, but he kept eyes on her and tried.

"Just planning choreography for tomorrow."

"It's going well?"

She stepped forward and jumped off the stage, landing deftly. She gave him a tight smile before she grabbed one of her bags and began filling it. "It's going quite well, thank you," she answered, more diplomatic than anything. "I'm pleased with the quality I'm finding here. I expect I may only need another week, and then we can head back to Nar Shaddaa."

She crossed forward then, her arm reaching onto the stage to grab that fat, pink disk. She checked it for something first–some image popped up–and she shrewdly scrutinized it in silence.

"If you needed a comm," he interjected, "something smaller than that would do."

Her head lifted after a lag, that mouth still flat. "Rosie's not just a comm," she explained. "I keep all kinds of things on here."

"Like what?" he queried, unable to curb the slight mocking tone in his voice.

"All my files. Contact info, everything related to the theater, choreography. And maybe most importantly, all my music." She studied him again, squinting. "What kind of music do you like?"

He gaped at her first, shifting his weight over. "Uh, I'm…I'm not much of a music guy."

She remained still. "What do you mean?"

"I mean…I don't know." He shuffled again. "I don't really listen."

"*Ever*?"

"Well," he flustered, a heat flushing his neck, "if it's playing in the background, sure, but I don't–I don't keep up with it."

She cooled, looking long at him down her nose. "Well, I certainly hope that's not true of your colleagues." And then she waited a beat, perhaps anticipating he might have some kind of rebuttal, but as silence hovered between them, she turned back to her business.

Foiled, he watched her pack up, reaching for what else he could say that might turn his situation around. Coming up empty, he audited her–she was head-to-toe in black again, except for her feet, which were bound in nude colored shoes. He squinted, realizing they were linework shoes, a discipline he'd only heard of in professional productions in the Core.

Genuine curiosity pulled at him. "How do those things work?" he asked, pointing at her unique shoes.

Her eyes followed his, and with a small smirk, she lunged forward and started rummaging into one of her bags. Finding another pair, she chucked a single shoe at him. He caught it and turned it in his hands. The shoe was clearly worn, as the silky material it was wrapped in was fraying, especially where the flat toe piece met the ground. He thumbed the frayed edge, then squeezed and bent the shoe as he could to find it had a rock hard toe but a semiflexible arch. He frowned– how did something this uncomfortably stiff and yet pliable allow for what he'd seen linework dancers do?

His eyes turned back up to her, his forehead lined in skepticism. "Does it hurt?"

She crossed over to him, delicately taking the shoe back. "Often in the beginning, yes. But with practice, your feet get stronger and the skin gets calluses in just the right places. And I don't dance in these as–" she hesitated, trying to find the right word, "*aggressively* as some of the professionals do. About half the time, I'm just wearing these for show." Turning away from him, she resumed cleaning up.

Han stood there for a while, watching her again with folded arms. She at least had dropped the curt answers–a good sign. It would be smart for him, though, to push further. If this girl had the kind of pull that Deino had warned about, then a glowing report might win him favor.

Propping himself up on his arms, he leaned back into one of the theater seats, wryly cocking his head. "So what's this thing you're putting together? What's this dance hall?"

Hunched on the floor to remove the ribbons tied tight at her ankle, she slowed at his question, then slowly picked her head up and scrutinized him. In her narrowed eyes, he sensed detection, and he already started to think of his cover before she turned her attention back to her task and began to answer. "It's a performance hall. Essentially, I and all these other dancers I'm hiring will be choreographing and dancing in a show set to music."

"What kind of dance?" He pointed at her shoes again. "Like that?"

"Sometimes," she answered.

He waited for her to say more, but she seemed content with her answer. Instead, the dance shoes came off and she effortlessly slipped into street shoes, packed a few more small items away, then stood, shrugging a bag over her shoulder. A second she lifted, then turned and approached Han, tossing it to him to carry.

"Let's go," she directed, clipped yet bright, and then swiftly passed him, heading for the exit.

Han followed, hustling a bit to catch up with her and throwing the bag over his shoulder; if she intended to be evasive, she'd have to try harder. "So, where's this theater gonna be at?" he questioned, trying to mimic the upbeat way she 'made conversation.'

She snarked. "You know, for someone who keeps trying to act like he doesn't care, you're certainly asking a lot of questions."

He refused to take her bait. "So nowhere good, huh?"

"On the far end of the Promenade," she answered breathily, "past the Hutt casinos."

"You're settin' up *there*?" he balked, then whistled. "That's a pretty rough area."

Vexation pulled at her temple but she restrained herself, still walking ahead of him into the threshold. "Well, I can't be too far away from the Hutts, now, can I? Nor can I be too far from my clientele."

"Why–*who do you expect will come to this show?!*" he barked, skeptical, trying to block her exit.

She smiled again, pleased with herself, hand on the door release to step out onto the avenue. "I'm aiming toward most of the people who are on Nar Shaddaa–smugglers and the like."

He tried to make that make sense, but he couldn't shake his pessimism. There were no other productions like that on Nar Shaddaa or even near the Smuggler's Moon. No wonder she'd had a difficult time finding any talent.

"How many people you hirin'?" he continued.

She kept her eyes forward as they made their way down the street. Even with all her stuff, she moved at a quick clip, and Han found himself trotting a few times to keep up. "I need to leave here with about thirty. I don't *need* thirty, but I figure I will always lose some to attrition."

"They're not coming back with us, are they?!" he panicked.

She choked out a laugh before her face settled into the teasing knowing of narrowed eyes. "Of course not–you don't have room on your ship for any more than three or four passengers. Besides, these people are uprooting their whole lives. Not everyone can do that at the drop of a hat, Captain Solo."

He squinted at her. "That's what you think I do?"

"I'd bet the contents of this comm that you do," she retorted, waving the pink disk in her hand.

"And what makes you so damn sure?" he countered, not sure himself how much of his irritation was feigned.

Her mien retreated into a measured poise. She held his attention first, watching him wait for her, before she slightly leaned closer to answer. "People will tell you who they are, Captain Solo," she

waxed. “You just have to watch and listen.”

Something about the way she said it made his spine itch. His laugh, and the bravado that followed, came out forced. “If you think you can get a read on me, think again, doll. You won't.”

She blinked, unfazed, and her coyness relaxed into that cool confidence. “Who’s to say I haven’t already?” She assessed him again, a tauntness to her temple. “Besides, you’re not exactly subtle.”

As much as he felt himself posturing, her words barbed him. “Maybe I don’t want to be,” he responded, trying to pull himself up into an untouchable confidence. He could hear himself fail.

Her eyes danced over him in a way that made his skin crawl. She smirked, savvy and satisfied. “And that tells me something, too.”

Though he’d prefer it had stayed concealed, he knew his face betrayed him with a withdrawal of disgust. Or maybe something else…but something uncomfortable regardless, that same feeling he’d gotten when he’d stepped out onto Esseles the day before last, that creeping sense of *exposure*, vulnerability, that instigated a pressing urge to hide.

He’d not retreat, though, not to give her the upper hand or the satisfaction. He needed to give it right back to her, let her know he could tussle just as much in this game of intimidation. “You’re gonna need to tell me your secret,” he announced, his chest puffing with bravado.

Those eyes darted up in surprise. “My *secret*?”

“How you got the Hutts to agree to your little project.” He snarked a laugh. “It’d be mighty useful to be able to convince the Hutts to do what I wanted.”

Her eyes widened, mocking him. “I don’t get the Hutts to do whatever I want.”

“You’re gettin’ away with a lot, though, you can’t deny that,” he responded, brows raised. “How?”

Abruptly, she stopped, and he with her. She frowned at him, then her head swept left, then right, clearly taking in her surroundings. Satisfied enough, she cocked her head. “Do you like

working for the Hutts?"

He shrugged at her question. "It's fine. There's work, they pay consistently–"

"Jabba likes you," she added for him.

He couldn't help a snort of surprise, then grinned, smarmy. "Yeah, he does."

"How did you get him to like you?" She asked as though she already knew the answer.

He laughed, uncertain. "He just does, I guess."

"You're reliable. You're available, you do the job, you don't cause trouble." She gave a small shrug. "Same with me and Jiliac. He wants to feel like he can trust the people he does business with. When it comes to his dancers, I've watched so many of them make it very clear that they don't care." Here, she hesitated, something lingering at her lips until she rubbed them together and swallowed it down. "I'm good at what I do. And thank goodness, because Jiliac is very finicky and hard to satisfy."

"And *you* satisfy him?" The disbelief was evident in his voice.

"Obviously, or else would I be where I am right now?"

He scanned her quickly, aware of her point. "So you're saying…Jiliac has a crush on you?"

She shook her head tightly, rejecting his interpretation as she started down the street again. "He sees me as the most dedicated dancer he's ever had. In return, he wants to spoil me. This dance venue–this is him spoiling me."

"And allegedly making the Hutts a lot of money," he interjected, sardonic, "though that's yet to be seen." He grinned at his dig first, then continued. "But I don't get it. There's already tons of clubs in the Entertainment District. The Golden Orb, Jarinda's, the Cab–"

"You sound pretty familiar with those," she taunted.

She'd caught him off guard, but he recovered quickly. "Hey, not me. I don't go to those places. I don't *need* to go to those places. But they exist. Why would Jiliac let you set up another one?"

They came to the entrance of the hotel, and in all the bustling company, relegated themselves to silence. Only when they had privacy again in front of the lift did she turn to answer him, eyes narrowed but playful.

"Don't get the wrong idea about this place. It's not going to be a spot for smugglers to chase skirts or buy company."

"Then what is it?" he leered.

"It's a dance venue, like I told you," she answered, stepping onto the lift and selecting her floor.

"With no call girls and classical dance," he quipped as he followed her. "You think smugglers are going to come to a place like that?"

Her eyes narrowed in consideration first, though she grinned as she answered. "I can't manage a dance hall like you'd find somewhere nicer, where the productions are all squeaky clean. The people in Hutt Space have no interest in that. Who *are* there are a bunch of smugglers, many of whom are lonely as you pointed out, who nonetheless will enjoy our performances because they will cater to a variety of…" She hesitated. "Tastes."

He smirked devilishly to have caught her. "You mean sexual appetites. So you *are* looking to put skirts up for sale."

She narrowed her eyes at him again. "Why, are you interested?"

He instantly recoiled, shaking his head as though to end the conversation. "I told you, not my kind of place."

She raised her chin in victory, savoring her win for a moment before continuing. "I won't get in anybody's way if that's something they'd like to offer, but it's not the purpose of the venue. I know who my audience is, but there will be so much more than just that. I've figured out the balance between the two extremes. There will be beautiful, dancing, half-naked women and alcohol. That will get them in the door, and then the quality of the show will make them stay." She leveled her gaze at him. "Yes, Captain Solo, the smugglers will come, and they will love it."

He took her in: she had quite the self-satisfied smirk on her face and was poised for his retort. He had to admit, he was impressed at least with her confidence.

The lift chimed and they stepped out onto her floor. They carefully maneuvered past a few people trying to get on, and then started down the corridor to her door.

"And who is gonna let all these customers know that they have to keep their hands to themselves? Pirates especially ain't so good at taking no for an answer."

She laughed. "Isn't that the damn truth. I've got it covered. I have a good team of security to help everyone stay in their lane."

The bald guy with the thick neck, Han remembered. Yeah, he'd not be eager to get into a fist fight against him–he had hands that looked like they could crush durasteel–but against a vibroblade? A blaster?

They came to her room. While she toyed with the access panel, he continued. "I don't know. Sounds to me like this is a waste. Ain't no way the smugglers of Nar Shaddaa are gonna take to something that's even a lick of fancy, and you're gonna have your hands full trying to set them straight."

The door unlocked and swept aside. She stepped in, blocking the doorway with her body while she unburdened herself. Turning back to him slowly with those feline, knowing eyes and a slight smile, she reached out and plucked her bag off his shoulder.

"Well, Captain Solo, one of us is going to end up right," she waxed, eyes twinkling. "We'll just have to see who."

He let out a low, satisfied chuckle. "We'll see all right," he said, that familiar cocky edge back in his voice. "But don't say I didn't warn you."